

chettan set the record, I felt I also wanted to do something similar.”

Unfortunately for Afsal, that 2018 race marked the beginning of a prolonged period of stagnation. While the Air Force job afforded financial security, there was no scope to upscale his training methods or participate in international-level meets.

This was also the only phase of Afsal’s career that lacked appropriate guidance, an untethered spell between the coaching stints of Manoj and Ajith.

“Despite trying my best, I was not able to go under 1:48.00. My mind started drifting. I was really close to giving up on athletics,” says Afsal.

The nadir came in 2021, when he was ejected from the pre-Olympics national camp after he twisted his ankle.

“I returned to the Air Force for rehab. I was unfocused, gained a bit of weight,” admits Afsal.

Just when Afsal’s athletics career looked set to burn out in the shadows, fate intervened.

Trying to

break the slumber, a still-out-of-sorts Afsal ran at the 2021 Inter-Services meet in Bhubaneswar.

Despite finishing a disappointing third that day, Afsal managed to gain something even more valuable — a new mentor, in the form of Ajith, a techie-turned-track coach.

During the 2022 Inter-Services meet, Ajith was at the same venue, setting up Reliance’s high-performance centre there. As he was sitting in his office, he heard the gun for the 800m race.

Out of curiosity, he stepped out in time to watch Afsal struggle to a bronze-medal finish. But where others saw a fading runner, Ajith saw a diamond in the rough.

“I have known Afsal since 2012, having seen him do well in various meets. So I knew his potential,” explains Ajith.

“Afsal has this rare combination of speed, aerobic capacity, finishing ability and strength. What he was lacking was race discipline and execution,” says Ajith.

Joining hands with Reliance also provided Afsal with the tools and freedom to focus fully on his craft. From the high-altitude training

facility and diet to recovery and top-end shoes, Afsal doesn’t have to worry about anything now. Meanwhile, Ajith provided the nuanced direction he had previously lacked.

One major change Ajith has instilled is shortening Afsal’s stride length. The benefits were two-fold — fewer injuries and quicker lap times.

“Overstriding can cause hamstring/heel injuries. And for speed, what matters is contact time on the ground. The less, the better. By correcting his stride pattern, we reduced his contact time,” explains Ajith.

Besides Afsal’s obvious physical qualities, Ajith cites something else as the base of their fruitful association. “He is very loyal and trustworthy. He’ll open up about what he feels. That’s helped the process a lot.”

The synchronisation is a two-way

Chasing efficiency: One major change Ajith has instilled is shortening Afsal’s stride length. The benefits were two-fold — fewer injuries and quicker lap times. M. PERIASAMY

